Questions to Ask

Leading with AI. The questions from every session, for your vendors, your IT and data teams, and your board. Bring it to the next AI proposal you review.

Session 1: AI that sees and reads: images, documents and speech

Ask	Why it matters
What photos, pages or recordings did it learn from?	It only knows the kind it was shown
Were they like ours: our cameras, forms, languages, light?	A new kind of image breaks it
How often is it right on our own samples?	The vendor's score was on their images
What does it do with a photo it cannot read?	A good tool says "not sure"
Who checks what it flags, and who reviews a "no" about a person?	People answer for the decision
Where do our images and recordings go?	Photos and voices can be personal data

Session 2: AI that predicts from your data

Ask	Why it matters
What records did it learn from, and how many of each outcome?	A rare outcome with few examples gives a weak model
What was the score on records it never saw?	The score on records it has seen flatters
Who set the cut-off, and what does moving it cost?	Every cut-off trades risk against work
What has changed since those records were made?	A new product or a drought breaks the pattern
Who decides the close calls, and can a customer ask why?	Customers expect a reason; check your legal duties
How will we know, each month, that it still works?	Patterns drift as the world changes

Session 3: Is it any good? Accuracy claims and the cost of mistakes

Ask	Why it matters
How rare is the thing it looks for, in cases like ours?	When it is rare, accuracy flatters
Of the real cases, how many does it catch?	Each miss costs a loss
Of its alarms, how many are real?	Each false alarm costs work and goodwill
Measured on which cases: learned-from, kept aside, or ours?	Only unseen and own cases are fair
How does it compare with doing nothing, and with our current rule?	A tool must beat the simple option
Are the mistakes spread evenly across groups?	Bias hides inside a good total

Session 4: AI that understands language: sort, search, translate and summarise

Ask	Why it matters
Which languages does it handle, and was it tested on ours?	Quality falls where a language has little text
How often is it right on our own messages, ones it never saw?	The vendor's demo text is cleaner than yours
Does it show the top few results and the source passage?	A person can then choose and check

Ask	Why it matters
How does it handle slang, spelling slips and mixed languages?	Customers write the way they speak
Where do our messages and documents go, and who can read them?	Contracts and complaints hold personal data
How does a customer reach a person, and how fast?	Loops with no exit lose customers

Session 5: Generative AI: how chatbots write, and why they sometimes invent

Ask	Why it matters
Where do our prompts and documents go, and are they kept?	Staff paste in customer and company data
Can it answer from our own documents and show the source?	Answers from memory invent more
How often does it invent on our kind of questions?	Test it on twenty questions with known answers
Who checks and signs what it drafts?	The organisation answers for it
What happens when it does not know?	A good tool says so, and routes to a person
Who tests it again after each update?	DPD's bot changed after an update

Session 6: The AI market: models, vendors, and buy, rent or build

Ask	Why it matters
Which model is underneath, and who made it?	Many products sit on another maker's model
Where is our data stored and used, and are you registered with the PDPO?	Uganda's law follows the data
What does each use cost at our volume, and how can prices change?	Renting grows with every request
How do we leave, and in what format do we get our data back?	Lock-in is cheapest to fix before you sign
What happens to our service if you are bought or close?	Babyl Rwanda's users found out
What was the score on a sample of our own work?	A benchmark is someone else's test

Session 7: Getting good work from AI assistants: prompting for leaders and teams

Ask	Why it matters
Which tasks do we already use assistants for, approved or not?	Shadow use is common; find it first
Which briefs were tested on ten real tasks, and what was the count?	One good reply can be luck
Who checks figures, names and promises before anything is sent?	A wrong run sounds as sure as a right one
Which of our tasks sit outside the frontier?	There, people who trust it do worse
What may never be pasted in?	Customer and staff data follow Uganda's law
Who keeps the shared brief library up to date?	Models change, and briefs need retesting

Session 8: Making AI know your business: assistants on your own documents

Ask	Why it matters

Which documents may it read, and who owns each one?	Messy or out-of-date pages give wrong answers
Does every answer name its source, and can staff open it?	A source lets anyone check in seconds
What does it say when the documents are silent?	“Not stated” is safer than a guess
How were the documents cut, and was it tested?	A bad cut hides answers that are there
Could we paste the document instead of building search?	Start on the lowest step that works
Where do our documents go, and who else can see them?	Check data location and Uganda’s data law

Session 9: When AI goes wrong: failures, risk and checking

Ask	Why it matters
Which of the five failures is most likely here, and what would it cost?	Checking should match the cost of an error
What did it score on our own ten questions, against doing nothing?	A vendor’s score is on its tests
Does every answer show its source, and do we open it?	Catches invented facts and missed pages
What can it do without a person approving?	Hidden instructions matter when it can act
Who owns it, and how do staff report an error?	Errors nobody reports are never fixed
When do we rerun the test, and who compares results by group?	Drift and bias appear slowly

Session 10: AI agents: delegating work that acts

Ask	Why it matters
Which keys does it hold: read, write, send, spend?	The keys set the worst case
What can it do without a person approving?	Anything that cannot be undone must wait
Who owns it, and who reads the log?	A team often means nobody
How fast can we switch it off?	Minutes, by removing its access
What does it do with instructions inside emails or files?	Hidden instructions turn reading into acting
Is it a real agent, and what will it cost to run?	Gartner expects many projects to be cancelled

Session 12: Leading people through AI: roles, skills, adoption and change

Ask	Why it matters
Which tasks change in each role, and by how much?	Jobs change task by task
Who carries the change: staff, contractors, new hires?	Contractors are often hit first and told last
What do we promise, and can we keep it?	A broken promise costs more than the tool saves
What training does each level need, and when?	Only 36 in 100 staff feel trained enough
Who are our champions, and do they have time?	Adoption stalls without guidance
How will staff report errors without blame?	Hidden errors become customer problems

Session 14: Data readiness, AI roadmap and your 90-day plan

Ask	Why it matters
Which sources will it use, and who owns each one?	With no owner, nobody fixes the faults

Ask	Why it matters
Who may see this data, and is any of it personal?	Rights is the Red that stops the work
How many faults did you count, and in which columns?	A count beats an opinion
Where will the data be stored and processed?	Location and the law, as in Sessions 6 and 13
Which 20 questions will we test it on, and what score is good enough?	Write the line for success first
Who keeps the data clean after the pilot?	Data slips back without an owner